THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

PART VI

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, July 3, 1845*

When you can find a few spare minutes to write to me I shall be glad to hear how you are employed. I continue to write you every three months. And I trust this will find you safely returned from America. The last news we had from England was Sir Rt Peel declaration about Oregon. I sincerely trust we shall have no war, and the missionaries here who are to a man conservatives (whigs I think the Americans call them) and anti slavery men, think there will be none because they say that altho Polk was elected by the low party theirs is still strong enough to prevent mischief. I hope so.

I have been pruning a vine this morning; vines in this country are pruned twice a year, first in March, before they shoot, and again now. For many years I always had a gardener to prune the vine opposite my windows and I was surprised that it grew no bigger, at last I found that they cut it as they cut the vines in their vineyards, so as to bear much fruit and grow no bigger, last year I gave it the second pruning myself, and this year both. And it has already increased one third and I hope this year to train it from end to end of the court-yard, about twenty yards, it is already more than half across. Notwithstanding the tremendous cutting I gave it in the spring it has on it as fine a crop of grapes as I recollect to have seen; I cut it so as to send all the force of the sap into the outside branches on both sides and I cut away much of the sound bearing wood, and did not expect this year that it would have any fruit on it, or at least very little. I believe vines might be cultivated with success in England. The intense cold of last winter some forty degrees more intense than it was with you has not injured my vine at all. It is scarcely necessary to remind you that vines in this country are unprotected in the winter from the cold except the protection they get from a covering of snow.

A Mr Mann, formerly a clerk in the foreign office, has arrived here lately from England and goes on to take his place as attaché to the mission at Tehran; he is quite a young man, intelligent and agreeable, and I wish he was going to stay here. I do not think he will remain long at Tehran, he will find it so dull, though according to all accounts, better now than last year, as Col Farrant and Dr Bell, lately joined, and they talk, the others are as silent as trappist monks. Some years ago when the elder brother of this Dr Bell was there, he being a jolly fellow disliked eating every day in silence, and they say, for mind I am not answerable for the truth of the story, that he would at dinner some times talk

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out loud to himself, just to relieve the monotonous silence of the room. They formerly saw nothing of the Persians, never visited with them and I suspect knew very little of what was going on in the country. Col Farrant is a very different man. Last year he ran a four in hand sledge at Erzeroom. None of the horses having been in harness before and now I understand he is going to ride a tandem about Tehran. Many Persians have set up carriages but the streets are so narrow that they are obliged to keep them outside the town; in the neighbourhood the roads are not bad, that is for Persia.

The Greek merchants are much frightened because an English house has set up at Shiraz. They think and not without some reason that the British trade may be drawn that way. That it may pass through Busheer instead of Trebizonde. Unless the Englishmen who are established at Sheeraz are very sharp fellows they can not compeat with the Greeks who are the cleverest merchants I have ever seen. There are already three houses here all of them extensive, and another in a small way, more I expect will be coming. Their trade is almost entirely with Manchester where they have agents. They have driven the Persians and English almost entirely out of the trade. The Persians formerly went to Constantinople and bought goods of the English settled there; now that trade has almost entirely ceased and the same goods come here through the Greeks direct from Manchester. There is some talk of the Russian Government allowing British goods to enter Georgia at a small duty if this takes place the trade of Tabreez will suffer much.

P. S.: I have not thanked you for the book you so kindly sent me viz "Howitts visits to remarkable places."[91] It has interested me much altho I am not acquainted with the places he describes. It stirs up in me that love of country which is so strong in all Englishmen and when reading it I think how little I have seen of my own country.

[Edward Burgess to Mrs. Henry Burgess]* *Tabreez, July 4, 1845*

I wrote to you by last post probably the *7th* or *8th* ult. and since then I have to thank you for yours of the 10*th* May. I am glad you liked my Persian writing and if I thought you had not had enough I would send you some more of it. You seem to think this hand writing complex. It something resembles what answers to round hand. I must send you a specimen of the hand writing called "shekesteh" broken, much of which resembles fishhooks one within the other. There is one thing which makes writing or speaking in Persia agreeable, it is this: That unlike England where most people write and speak English perfectly well, and where

[91] Howitt, William. *Visits to remarkable places, old halls, battle fields, and scenes illustrative of striking passages in English history and poetry.* London, 1840.

* Unless otherwise noted, all letters in this installment are to Mrs. Burgess.

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to hear broken English spoken is a rarity, you find many of the first men in the country who can not speak Persian, others who can not speak Turkish and again some who speak nothing but Koordish. This makes the natives of the country lenient to a foreigner, they try to help him on and sometimes will speak broken Persian and Turkish themselves thinking he will understand them better; and as to writing there are some men of rank who do not write so well as I do; altho education in Persia is very general, particularly in midland Persia, still you find many men of rank who do not read or write at all. I have met learned men, who have been well read in Persian and Arabic literature driving mules or working in melon grounds. I pay one sailcroon (shilling) a month for the schooling of a little boy the son of my servant. This cheapness enables many to learn. But many after thirty years study can not earn so much as they can gardening or mule driving, and they prefer those healthy occupations to living in a small cell in the center of a filthy city.

I think Sir Robt Peel is quite right about Maynooth and can not understand why my fellow country-men should be so illiberal.[92] Your political remarks are very clever and to me most amusing altho I often disagree with you. In reading over the newspapers, I often say to myself I shall be curious to see what my dear Mother will think of this, then in a few days comes your letter. Poor Sir Robert. How you clapper-claw him. But if I recollect right you used to be-maul Lord John Russel[93] and the Whigs just as much. I am also much amused at Catharine Foljambe's admiration of the knights of old. I think there is more real courage and gallantry displayed by a captain of black infantry in the companies service at such a fight as that of Hyderabad[94] than in a whole life of one of those worthies who would ride down and slaughter the foot soldiers, themselves being cased in steel. And as to honour and morality, why there are very few noble families in England some of whose ancestors have not robbed on the high-way. Vide R: Random, Rob Roy etc– Though I confess this same robbing on the high-road is to me amongst the least of their crimes. I have known many a good fellow in Persia who had occasionally been out on that account. In many parts of Koordistan most young men of family do it; if two parties meet, its either we strip you, or you strip us, and the party who are beaten, are stripped. This sort of robbing does no great harm. But the sort of robbing I would hang men for is this; suppose a poor villager has taken a few mule-loads of dried fruits or other merchandize to Baghdad and after having risked his life and what is perhaps worse, his health in the burning and sandy deserts or snowy mountains, and is

[92] Sir Robert Peel was Prime Minister from 1841–1846. The increased endowment to the Irish college of Maynooth aroused considerable local opposition in England.

[93] The Opposition to the Peel government; later his successor as prime minister.

[94] An incident in Lord Ellenborough's successful enterprise to conquer the Gwalior district for the British.

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returning with a little money and some chintz or silks to make clothes for his wife and children with whom he hopes to pass the winter months happily, and when within a few miles of home, some Koordish horseman, who like Catharine's man at arms has done nothing all the year round but swagger about with his sword and lance [, robs him]; this man I would hang on the highest tree I could find, and perhaps with as little pity as I would kill a wild duck.

P: S: *7th* July. I add this post script to salute my dear Father and you upon my birthday. I dine at M' d'Ozeroffs to night it being the birth day of the Emperor, so I hope to drink your healths in iced champaigne. The courier arrived from Tehran yesterday but we have nothing in the way of news, except the marriage of the Heir Apparent,[95] at which they had seven days feasting etc. at which the Shah entertained a whole camp of poor people, Mahomedans, Armenians and Jews who encamped close to his palace outside the town.

Tabreez, August 6, 1845

We had a smart shock of an earthquake on the 9th July or rather two, one early in the morning. I had been up about an hour and was smoking my first pipe after coffee, it might have been at about six o'clock. This was very slight. The other was about twelve, mid-day; the meerza (secretary) and I were busy making up our monthly newspaper; it was a strong trembling motion but not so violent as I have formerly felt, and of much longer duration. The Meerza said, "wī wī zilzilla" (clap clap an earthquake) and we both rose and went to the window. But did not run out. We stood some time and when I sat down the ground was still trembling; these earthquakes were felt exactly at the same time at Merrend a town forty miles north and Ouroumia a town 80 miles west of this and I believe in the surrounding districts. At Merrend the mid-day one was rather violent and threw down some walls and houses, I believe one man was killed and several hurt. I have almost made a resolution never to run out of a house for an earthquake. Most people when an earthquake occurs jump out of windows or run out of doors to get out of the way of the falling walls. And I have seen so many accidents in the falling of people one over another, and crowds rushing together etc. that I have almost determined never to run.

I believe my affairs will shortly call me to Tehran. For I have been endeavouring for the last two years, without success to come to some arrangement with my creditors and to do so I am now obliged to go to Tehran. I have not troubled you with these matters because it is by no means a pleasant subject to dwell upon and until something definite is arranged there is no use in it. I believe I shall

[95] This would be Nasir i Din, then fifteen years of age.

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have to give up everything even to my house and furniture and what perhaps vexes me more, my gun, horse and arms. This in fact I have offered to do if my creditors will give me a quittance which they as yet refuse to do.

Tabreez, December 10, 1845

I have been about sixteen days absent from Tabreez at Maranghd and the villages; and on my return here the 7th instt I found the monthly post had left the evening before. This was partly oweing to that slow man Dr. Cormick; he had come after me to the villages, and in returning, instead of riding thro' the eighty miles in twenty four or at most thirty or thirty two hours, as I usually do, we made four stages of it. I was much vexed, particularly as I am affraid since you are in the habit of receiving regular monthly letters from me you may be anxious at not hearing from me. I therefore send this by the post. You will have to pay for it but I believe now not much. I thought this better than waiting for the next monthly courier. I have written a long letter to you which is too heavy for this means of conveyance.

My journey to the villages was an agreeable one and they are going on very well, the farmers are breaking up much of the grass lands, which is a very good sign, because this, with their miserable ploughs is a most expensive and laborious process. I walked and rode about the grounds of the villages every day always accompanied by one or two of the farmers, and I learnt much about this mode of cultivation. The grass lands, they plough across and across, until they work out or destroy most of the weeds. They have no harrows, and I saw a piece of ground which had been ploughed over six times, and was still unfit for sowing. They smooth the ground by dragging over it a heavy plank of wood to which two oxen are yoked, and the man stands upon it. This breaks the clods: the seed having been first worked in with the plough.

I have not yet been to Tehran because Col Sheil now our envoy has again referred my case to the authorities at home, I believe the crown lawyers: he himself knows nothing of commercial matters. The Persians puzzle him, and he is affraid to act. My own position is much the same as formerly except that I am more comfortable. I have made something from the villages, am well with the Prince, and I may say pretty generally respected, — and being much in the Prince's confidence gives me a position with the people attached to this court which I did not enjoy even when I was a thriving merchant.

The experiment on the salt lands has not succeeded, the deeper I dug the salter the earth was; until I came to the sea sand or rather lake sand and salt water. Now as this plan has not succeeded here perhaps the Persian method may in England. That is by turning a stream of fresh water over land and banking

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it up there, letting it run gradually on and off, and standing on the land to the depth of a few inches. This soaks out the salt or rather so much of it as to render the land most productive for wheat, barley, melons cotton etc. I shall in a future letter give my dear Father as good a description as I can of this process, which as there is no want of fresh water in England may be adopted with advantage.

Whilst at Maranghd I procured from the Govr an order to enable us to bank up the river which in times of inundation passes our grounds. This dam had for many years been neglected and the water chiefly carried off by the farmers of another village who had no right to it. We shall have some difficulty but if done it will bring an immense tract of land into cultivation.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, January 10, 1846*

You appear surprised that no English merchants are settled here but will not be so when I tell you how the Greeks came to establish themselves here. You have perhaps heard that the Greeks had for many years an extensive trade chiefly in Manchester goods, at Constantinople. These goods were almost entirely sold to Persians who brought them here for consumption in the country, and exportation. They (the Greeks) had encouraged the Persians by giving them almost unlimited credit, and the consequence was that the latter, overdid the trade to such an extent that many sorts of goods were to be had cheaper retail in Tehran than they could be bought in Manchester. Extensive failures amongst the Persians followed and then some amongst the Greeks, and one or two of the Greek houses who were not ruined sent an agent here to dispose of the goods in Tabreez instead of selling them to the Persians to be so disposed of. Another reason the Greeks had for establishing houses here was that besides failing the Persians cheated them in many ways.

After they were settled here they began having new designs made in Manchester and to do this they have sometimes sent home a Cashmeer shawl the pattern of which suited the Persian taste, or had the design painted by Persian painters to send home. The prints so made are chiefly 5 Col[or] Prints costing about fifteen or sixteen shillings at Manchester and we will say the old patterns sold for about S25/ here. The new designs are printed in the same calicoe have the same colours in them and the same work as the old ones and cost very little more but being new they have sold as high as S40/. I have seen some of these prints made to imitate cashmeer so exactly that until within a few feet you could not tell the difference, and the shawl which they resembled could not cost less than 5 or 6 £ a yard, the print S 1/6/ here. You are wrong in supposing that merchants have little security for person and property in this country. They enjoy now many more priveleges than they did in Turkey and I think are much

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more secure. Since '42 we have had a regular commercial treaty with Persia and if there were any British merchants here I have no doubt they would be well protected. One of the reasons why they do not settle here is, I think, because they know little or nothing about the country and also the long time they would be before they had their returns. The proceeds of goods sent from Manchester to be sold in Tabreez could not well arrive in Manchester in less than twelve months and the profits on common goods are often not large enough to tempt men to embark in such a trade. The returns from this country are made in a great measure in Russian gold and Silver coin which comes in to pay for Persian silk (raw) dried fruits and other merchandize. Scarcely any Persian money now goes out of the country. Perhaps about one third of the imports of European manufactures may be paid for by raw silk and other Persian produce and the rest in Russian gold and silver. And it is rather curious that this Russian coin goes back to Russia from Constantinople to pay for corn bought at Odessa. I believe that at times there is more Russian money in circulation at Khoee, a Persian frontier town, than Persian.

February 8th. I believe I told you that last summer I translated some travels in China for the Prince. I am now expecting to go to Tehran and I have had a copy of my book neatly written out and I intend to present it to the King. They say he is fond of such things and I may get something for it. You know that in Persia most books are manuscript. And altho we have fifteen printing offices[96] in Tabreez the manuscripts are much more valuable. The writing this book cost me with the gilding etc. about S 20/ so you may suppose writing is pretty cheap in Persia. The book is about the size of a novel.

(To be continued)

[96] Probably an overestimate. The first known press was established in Tabriz in 1816; in 1825 Abbas Mirza sent a Persian to Russia to learn the lithographic process and a plant was established in Tabriz, which was shortly transferred to Tehran. In 1836 the American missionaries set up a printing plant at Urumia, chiefly for publications in Syriac. The first newspaper appeared in 1851 with Edward Burgess as its managing editor. Cf. E. G. Browne, *The Persian press and Persian journalism,* Cambridge, 1914.

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